

I44

Pontius Pilate

The Roman governor who found no fault in Jesus and handed him over to be crucified.

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26 to 36. He held the power of life and death, and so Jesus' trial ended before him. All four Gospels show a man who questioned Jesus, found no fault in him, and tried several ways to let him go. He sent him to Herod, offered the crowd Barabbas, and had him scourged in the hope that it would be enough. In the end he gave way to pressure, washed his hands, and handed Jesus over to be crucified. He is the only Roman official named in the ancient Christian creeds. His question, "What is truth?", still hangs in the air.

At a glance

Name	Pontius Pilatus, in Latin
Office	Roman prefect, or governor, of Judea, AD 26–36
Base	Caesarea on the coast; in Jerusalem at the great feasts
Emperor	Tiberius (Luke 3:1)
Family	A wife who warned him about Jesus (Matthew 27:19)
Key people	Jesus, Caiaphas and the chief priests, Herod Antipas, Barabbas, Joseph of Arimathea
Main passages	Matthew 27; Mark 15; Luke 23; John 18:28–19:42
Later mentions	Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28; 1 Timothy 6:13

"Pilate saith unto him, What is truth? And when he had said this, he went out again unto the Jews, and saith unto them, I find in him no fault at all."

John 18:38, KJV

The life of Pontius Pilate

His years in office (AD 26–36) come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33.

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| c. AD 28–29
<i>Governor of
Judaea</i> | <div>●</div> Named in Luke's dating
Luke dates John the Baptist's call to the fifteenth year of the emperor Tiberius, "Pontius Pilate being governor of Judaea." <i>Luke 3:1</i> |
| Before AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | <div>●</div> Blood at the altar
Some tell Jesus of Galileans "whose blood Pilate had mingled with their sacrifices." Jesus uses the news to call his hearers to repent. Scripture gives no other details. <i>Luke 13:1–3</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Friday dawn</i> | <div>●</div> Questions Jesus
The chief priests bring Jesus, accused of claiming to be a king. Pilate examines him and finds no fault. Hearing that he is a Galilean, he sends him to Herod Antipas. <i>Luke 23:1–7; John 18:28–38</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Friday morning</i> | <div>●</div> Offers Barabbas
Hoping to release Jesus, he offers the crowd a choice of prisoner. His wife sends a warning after a dream. The chief priests stir the crowd, who ask for Barabbas. <i>Matthew 27:15–21</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Friday morning</i> | <div>●</div> Washes his hands
He has Jesus scourged and says, "Behold the man!" Fearing a riot and the charge of disloyalty to Caesar, he washes his hands before the crowd and hands Jesus over. <i>John 19:1–16; Matthew 27:24–26</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Friday and Saturday</i> | <div>●</div> Title, body and guard
He refuses to change the title "THE KING OF THE JEWS," grants Jesus' body to Joseph of Arimathea, and lets the chief priests seal and guard the tomb. <i>John 19:19–22, 38; Matthew 27:62–66</i> |

Key activities

Jesus told Pilate, "Thou couldest have no power at all against me, except it were given thee from above" (John 19:11). The Gospels show Pilate as both unwilling and responsible, and Acts 4:27–28 places the whole event within God's purpose.

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- 1 **Examined Jesus.** He asked, "Art thou the King of the Jews?" and heard that Jesus' kingdom was not of this world. *John 18:33–37*
 - 2 **Asked about truth.** He asked, "What is truth?" and went out without waiting for an answer. *John 18:38*
 - 3 **Declared him innocent.** Three times he said he found no fault in Jesus. *Luke 23:4, 14, 22*
 - 4 **Sent him to Herod.** He tried to pass the case to Herod Antipas, who sent Jesus back. *Luke 23:6–12*
 - 5 **Offered Barabbas.** He hoped the crowd would choose Jesus, but they chose Barabbas. *Mark 15:6–15*
 - 6 **Washed his hands.** He said, "I am innocent of the blood of this just person: see ye to it." *Matthew 27:24*
 - 7 **Gave in to pressure.** When the crowd cried, "If thou let this man go, thou art not Caesar's friend," he delivered Jesus to be crucified. *John 19:12–16*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Pilate.

Old Testament

Psalm 2:1–2	Rulers against the LORD's anointed; applied to Pilate (Acts 4:25–27)
Echo: Isaiah 53:7	Like a sheep before her shearers, he is silent
Echo: Deuteronomy 21:6–7	Elders wash their hands to declare innocence of blood

New Testament

Matthew 27; Mark 15; Luke 23; John 18:28–19:42	The four trial accounts
Luke 3:1; 13:1	Pilate as governor, and the Galileans he killed
Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28	The apostles name his part in Jesus' death
1 Timothy 6:13	Christ's good confession before Pontius Pilate
Tradition	The Apostles' Creed: Jesus "suffered under Pontius Pilate"

For discussion

- Observe:* How many times does Pilate say he finds no fault in Jesus (Luke 23:4, 14, 22)?
- Understand:* Pilate washed his hands, but was he free of responsibility? Why or why not?
- Apply:* Pilate knew what was right but feared the crowd. Where do you feel pressure to go along with others against your conscience?
- Apply:* Pilate asked, "What is truth?" and walked away. What truth do you need to stop and face this week?